Group and Intergroup Relations

Source: OpenStax, *Organizational Behavior* (2019), print ISBN 978-1-59399-877-6, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. Written from the openstax.org web edition (revised June 2026); wording may differ slightly from the printed copy.

THE CHAPTER IN 4 LINES

- A **group** = people who share **norms**, have **differentiated roles**, and **interact** toward **common goals**. Groups strongly shape individual behavior.
- Group **structure** = **roles, size, norms, status, cohesiveness**. Each affects behavior and performance.
- **Hackman's model**: inputs → effort + skill + strategy → effectiveness (output, satisfaction, future cooperation).
- **Between groups**: performance depends on **interdependence, information flow, integration**. Coordinate with rules, member exchange, linking roles, task forces, decoupling.

OPENING CASE: EA ENGINEERING, SCIENCE, AND TECHNOLOGY (BALTIMORE)

- **Multiple team membership (MTM)**: **81-95%** of employees worldwide are on several teams at once. This can raise stress; **leadership** offsets it. EA staff work on **up to 6 projects** at once.
- **Empowering leaders** make employees more **proactive**, and employees **carry that over** to their other teams, even under less empowering leaders.

9.1 Work Groups: Basic Considerations

- Coworkers strongly shape behavior. People **cap their own pay** to match the group, or **stay in bad jobs** for their friends.
- **Hackman & Morris**: "something important happens" in groups. Nobody agrees what, whether it helps or hurts, or how to manage it.
- **Four ways to define a group**: **perception** (members see themselves as a group); **structure** (McDavid & Harari: 2+ interrelated people performing a function, with standard role relationships and norms); **motivation** (being together is rewarding); **interaction** (how much members communicate over time).
- **Book's definition**: shared **norms** + differentiated **roles** + **interaction** toward **common goals**. Structure is covered here; processes later.

Table 9.1	Relatively permanent	Relatively temporary
Formal	**Command** (functional) group, e.g. the sales department	**Task group**, e.g. an affirmative-action task force
Informal	**Friendship group**: long-lasting	**Interest group**, e.g. a network of working women or minority managers; dissolves as interests change

- **Formal** groups are **set up by the organization** for assigned tasks: department sections, committees, task forces.
- **Informal** groups **arise naturally** from interests, social needs, or friendship. They make their own norms and unwritten rules, and can **help or hinder** performance.
- Both kinds demand **loyalty**, so being in many groups creates **conflicts**.

Six reasons people join groups

1. **Security**: "safety in numbers" against being fired, an intimidating boss, embarrassment, or loneliness.
2. **Social needs**: friendship and meaningful relationships.
3. **Self-esteem**: prestige, e.g. the National Academy of Sciences or a "million dollar club" for top salespeople.
4. **Economic self-interest**: unions, the American Bar Association. They **limit supply** to protect jobs and pay.
5. **Mutual interest**: goals not feasible alone, e.g. bridge clubs, company baseball teams.
6. **Physical proximity**: office layout shapes groups. Offices in a **row** mean less interaction; in a **cluster**, more. Neither is "better."

Tuckman's stages of group development (Exhibit 9.2)

1. Forming	Getting acquainted and testing each other; learning what behavior is acceptable. **New members rely on others for cues.**
2. Storming	**High conflict** as members fight for a place and try to shape norms and roles; goals get clarified. (The book says "intergroup" but means conflict inside the group.)
3. Norming	A sense of **oneness**. **Norms emerge**; members accept each other and share a purpose.
4. Performing	**Role differentiation** and specialization; the group focuses on the **task**.

Exhibit 9.2 shows group maturity rising, with a possible **"Failure?"** exit at every stage. Tuckman does **not** say every group goes through every stage; it is a general scheme.

9.2 Work Group Structure

Five structural properties: **roles, size, norms, status systems, cohesiveness**. They drive group **processes**: leadership, communication, decision-making, power and politics, conflict and negotiation (Exhibit 9.3).

(1) Work roles

- **Work role**: an **expected behavior pattern** attached to a position. **Role differentiation** = splitting up activities (leaders, workers, support).
- **Three role types**:
  - **Task-oriented**: reaching group goals.
  - **Relations-oriented**: cohesiveness, consensus, harmony, member welfare.
  - **Self-oriented**: personal needs, often **at the group's expense**.

  People often play several at once (a leader handles both task and harmony).

Role episode (Exhibit 9.4)		
1. Group's expectations for a position	Group, cognitive	Expected role
2. Expectations communicated	Group, behavior	
3. Individual perceives them	Individual, cognitive	Perceived role
4. Actual role behavior	Individual, behavior	Enacted role

Stage 4 feeds back into Stage 1.

- Example: the newest member must fetch coffee. The group decides (1) and tells them (2); they understand (3) and do it (4).
- **Role set** = all the roles one person holds.
- **Role conflict** = conflicting messages. **Role ambiguity** = unclear messages. **Role overload** = too many messages.

(2) Work group size: there is no "right" size

Table 9.2	Small	Large
Interaction	More	Less
Cohesiveness	Higher	Lower
Job satisfaction	Higher	Lower
Absenteeism	Lower	Higher
Turnover	Lower	Higher
Social loafing	Lower	Higher
Productivity	No clear relationship	

- **Bales & Borgatta**, using **interaction process analysis** ("who says what to whom"):
  - **Small (2-4)**: more tension, agreement, opinion seeking; harmony matters.
  - **Large (13-16)**: more tension release and giving information; people must be direct to get attention.
- **Satisfaction** drops with size; the link is consistent but not strong.
- **Absenteeism** rises with size for **blue-collar only**. White-collar workers have other ways to meet their needs. **Turnover** is higher in big groups.
- **Productivity depends on the task** (Mitchell). **Additive** tasks (piece-rate work): more people, more output. **Pooled** tasks: shrinking gains, then coordination and motivation problems.
- **Social loafing** = cutting effort on group tasks. It happens when (1) the task seems unimportant or simple, (2) individual output can't be identified, and (3) others are expected to loaf. **Worse in big groups.** Fix: more responsibility and more challenging work.

(3) Work group norms

- **Norm** = a **shared standard that regulates member behavior**. Examples: don't speak up too often in class; don't produce too much or too little; don't get too close to the boss; don't be late.
- **Five characteristics**:
  1. They summarize how the group influences members.
  2. They govern **behavior only**: **public compliance** is enough, not private agreement.
  3. They form only for behaviors **most members find important**.
  4. They develop gradually, or faster when the group needs protecting.
  5. They **don't apply to everyone** (newcomers fetch coffee; some depend on seniority, sex, race, class).
- **Four functions**:
  1. **Group survival** ("circle the wagons").
  2. **Simplify expected behavior**, making members predictable.
  3. **Avoid embarrassment**, e.g. no swearing.

4. **Identify the group** and its values (clothes, language), as rallying points.

- **Asch's conformity experiment** (Exhibit 9.5): a subject matched line X to A, B or C. The confederates all said C; A was clearly correct. In **over one-third of trials** the subject went along with the group, even when confident.
- **Three causes of conformity**:
  1. **Personality**: lower intelligence, tolerance, and ego strength, and higher authoritarianism, mean more conformity. A strong self-identity means more deviance.
  2. **Ambiguous stimulus**, e.g. a confusing order from the top, means more conformity (for security).
  3. **Group traits**: the pressure it applies, how much the member identifies with it, its past success.
- **Deviance**: groups first **increase communication toward the deviant**.
  - Janis's example, the **Bay of Pigs**: Robert Kennedy told dissenter Arthur Schlesinger, "the President has his mind made up. Don't push it any further." Janis called this **groupthink**.
  - If the deviant persists, the group **rejects or expels** them. That is easier than rethinking its own beliefs.

(4) Status systems

- **Five bases of status**: **birth** (the boss's son), **personal characteristics** (the brightest or strongest), **achievement** (the best performer), **possessions** (the highest paid), **formal authority** (the supervisor). Examples of status lines: blue/white/pink/gold collar, skilled/unskilled, senior/junior.
- **Four purposes**: **motivation** (status as a reward); **identification** (cues such as military rank and job titles); **dignification** (signals respect, e.g. clergy attire); **stabilization** (defines authority and roles, reducing ambiguity).
- **Offices signal status**: John Dean on Nixon's White House. A smaller office meant "on the way down"; carpenters in your office meant you were rising. Modern firms avoid walled-off offices to attract talent; one Orlando firm spent about **$330,000** on its build-out.
- **Status incongruence**: high on some dimensions, low on others, or a poor fit for the job.
  - Examples: a "college kid" summer janitor; the president's son; a young fast-track manager.
  - It causes jealousy and hostility, and coworkers ask "Why has this youngster been promoted over me when I have more seniority?"
  - Remedies (only promote people who "fit," or change group values) are **not realistic or fair**. So firms that reward **achievement over seniority must accept some conflict**.

BOX: STATUS IN JAPANESE BUSINESS

- Business cards are exchanged **before hello**; the lower-status person **bows lower**.
- Seats: in a car the top manager sits **behind the driver**. In an elevator the most junior stands at the controls. The honored seat is **farthest from the door**, and a sofa outranks armchairs.
- Status also recognizes **age**. Western managers who ignore these rules are at a **disadvantage**.

(5) Group cohesiveness

Group cohesiveness = the **extent to which members are motivated to stay in the group** ("us against them"). Shaw: cohesive members are more energetic, less often absent, and happy or sad with the group's success or failure.

Raised by (Exhibit 9.7):

- **Homogeneity** of members.
- **Maturity** (time together).
- **Small size**.
- **Frequent interaction**.
- **Clear goals**.
- **Competition or external threat**.
- **Past success**.

Consequences:

- **High** cohesiveness:
  - Members stay (low turnover).
  - The group has **power over members** when it is useful to their goals.
  - More **participation and loyalty**, less absence.
  - Higher **satisfaction**.
- **Low** cohesiveness: turnover and absence, member autonomy, isolation, lower satisfaction.

Exhibit 9.8	Accepts org goals	Rejects org goals
High cohesiveness	**High** perf.	**Low** perf.
Low cohesiveness	**Moderate** perf.	**Low** perf.

Cohesiveness alone doesn't predict productivity. It depends on **goal acceptance**. Rejecting org goals means low performance whatever the cohesiveness.

BOX: FORD F-150

- The 2015 redesign added a six-cylinder EcoBoost engine and an **all-aluminum body**. Planning began **18 months** ahead with **parallel teams** (more than 1,000 people) that met often and **shared feedback** ("everybody crosses boundaries").
- Results: **700 lb lighter, 29% better fuel economy**. Q3 earnings were $1.9B, up $1.1B. Pete Reyes: "We stuck to common goals."

9.3 Managing Effective Work Groups: Hackman's model

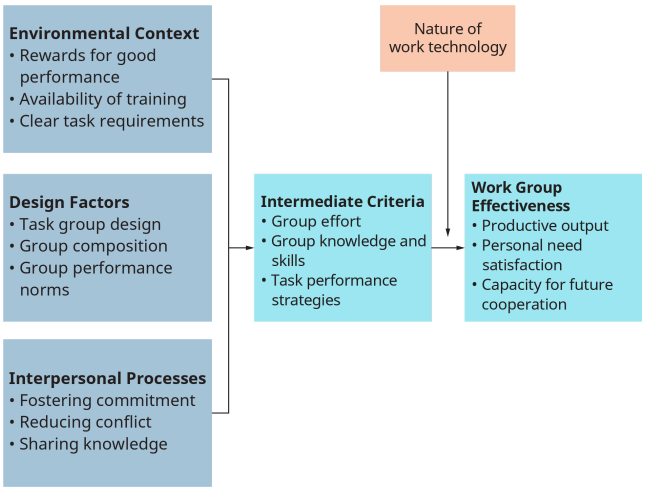


Exhibit 9.9: Determination of work group effectiveness (Hackman). Reproduced from OpenStax, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

- **Read it left to right**: three sets of inputs shape the **intermediate criteria**. Those, together with the **work technology**, decide **effectiveness**.
- **All three intermediate criteria are needed**: effort, knowledge and skill, and an appropriate task strategy (how the group analyzes and solves problems).
- **Work technology** (equipment, procedures, layout) decides which one matters most. On **routine** work, effort matters most. On **complex** work (R&D), effort is useless without skill.
- **Productive output** = meets the organization's quantity and quality standards. **Capacity for future cooperation** = avoiding destructive social processes so members can keep working together.

Four implications for managers:

1. **Awareness**: know why people join. Is cohesion a sign of **commitment or alienation**?
2. **Sensitivity to norms**: use OD "process consultation" to align norms with company goals.
3. **Understand conformity**: a mixed blessing. You want **dependable role performance** (follow procedures) but not to kill **innovative, spontaneous behavior**.
4. **Harness cohesiveness**: show why org goals benefit members, e.g. through the **reward system**.

Managers who ignore group processes get **"mediocre results" at best**.

9.4 Intergroup Behavior and Performance

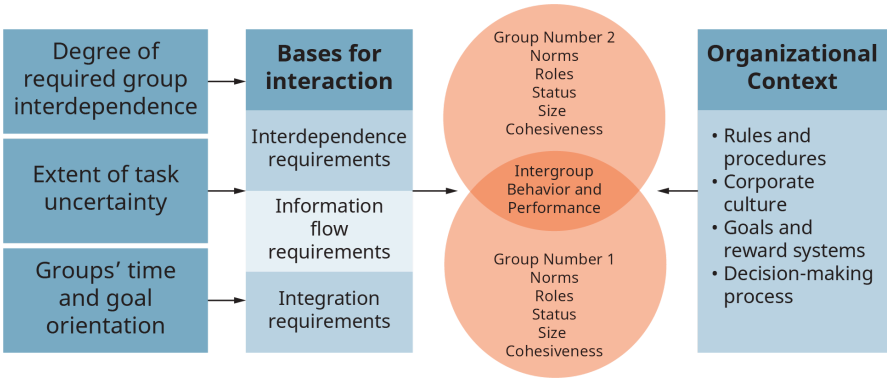


Exhibit 9.10: A model of intergroup behavior and performance. Reproduced from OpenStax, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

- Two groups, each with its own norms, roles, status, size, and cohesiveness, **overlap**. The overlap is intergroup behavior and performance.
- It all sits inside the **organizational context**: rules, culture, goals and rewards, decision process.
- Performance depends on **three requirements** (left side of the figure).

Requirement	Driven by	Key points
Interdependence	Required group interdependence	The interaction needed to coordinate resources. **More interdependence means more interaction is needed.** There are three forms (see below).
Information flow	**Task uncertainty**	Uncertain tasks (a new product, an experiment, an old product in a new market) need **more communication**. Uncertainty comes from **task clarity** (e.g. SOPs) and the **task environment** (how many groups are involved and how stable things are).
Integration	Time and goal orientation	Units differ: **research** is science-focused and long-term; **marketing** is market-focused and short-term; **production** is technical and moderate-term. The aim is a **shared coordinating mechanism**, **not** making units identical.

Three forms of interdependence:

- **Pooled**: largely independent units that each contribute to and draw on the organization, e.g. the physics and music departments, or consumer and industrial divisions whose products meet only in shipping.
- **Sequential**: one unit's **output is the next unit's input**. Manufacturing depends on purchasing much more than the reverse.
- **Reciprocal**: units **feed each other**. Marketing needs engineering's products, and engineering needs marketing's customer information. This needs the **most interaction**.

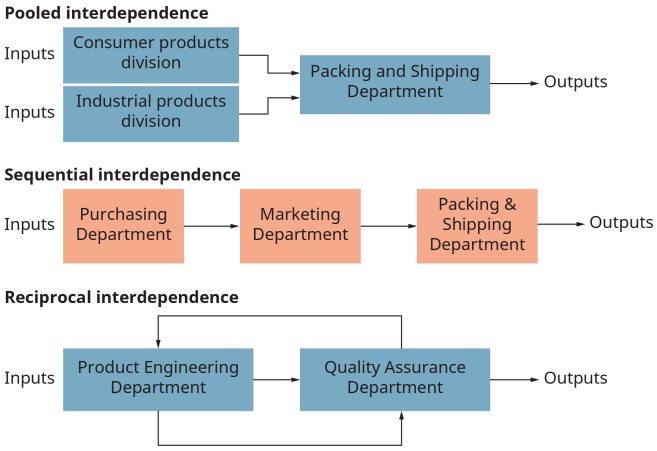


Exhibit 9.11: Three types of group interdependence. The figure's example departments differ a little from the text's. Reproduced from OpenStax, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

Table 9.3	Interdependence (R = reciprocal, S = sequential, P = pooled)	Uncertainty	Time / goal orientation
Research	R: development · S: market research · P: shipping	High	Long / science
Development	R: market research · S: manufacturing · P: shipping	Moderate-high	Long / science + techno-economic
Sales	R: market research · S: manufacturing · P: personnel	Moderate	Moderate / market
Manufacturing	R: accounting · S: shipping · P: research	Low	Short / techno-economic

Five coordination techniques (the key issue is coordination)

- **Rules and procedures**: e.g. require units to post information or announce changes on a schedule.
- **Member exchange**: a temporary transfer, e.g. a production engineer moves to QA. They learn and bring knowledge and contacts back.
- **Linking role**: a **permanent** coordinator, e.g. a **product manager** spanning manufacturing, sales, QC, and R&D (Exhibit 9.12).
- **Task force**: **temporary** cross-unit members solving a specific, urgent problem, e.g. a financial cutback or a foreign joint-venture offer (Exhibit 9.14).
- **Decoupling**: separate feuding groups **physically or administratively**. E.g. hardware engineers write specs and software engineers work separately to meet them. This keeps both groups.

The right choice depends on the situation. (The text mentions GM's Saturn as an example but gives no details.)

BOX: IBM GLOBAL TEAMS

- IBM has been a "globally integrated enterprise" since 2008, with more than 200,000 employees. It uses a **results-oriented work environment (ROWE)**: employees work where they live on virtual teams and set their own hours. Leadership teams are 4-5 senior executives from **several regions**.
- Three actions: grow locally and globally with one method; develop leaders early with global experience; build a collaborative, shared-values culture. Engaged leaders lead to engaged employees.

End-of-chapter cases

- **Potato chip plant**: the night shift is **22-23% more productive** (the book gives both numbers). The crew **cleans oil from the bagging tubes 7 times a night**; buildup slowed the whole line. Task: spread the practice across plants and reward supervisor **Manuel Santos** and the crew.
- **OECollaboration**: two new managers inherit established teams.
  - **Mike** imposed remote-work changes and mandatory 1:1s right away. Result: resentment and disengagement.
  - **Tracy** listened first, held 1:1s, aligned goals with members' skills, and explained *why* things changed. Result: trust.
  - Lesson: **build trust before imposing change**.
- **Self-assessments**. "How do you behave in a group?" has 12 items that read as 4 task, 4 relations, and 4 self-oriented behaviors (my reading; the scoring key is in Appendix B). "How effective is your work group?" has 20 yes/no items: relaxed atmosphere, clear goals, resolved disagreement, trust, cooperation, creativity, busy but not overloaded.

Adapted from OpenStax *Organizational Behavior* Ch. 9 (openstax.org), © Rice University, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0; shared under the same license.